



ROUTE 66

CENTENNIAL BUCKET LIST

66 Experiences. 8 States. One Centennial Year.

Chicago → Santa Monica · 2026 Edition

7,000+ travelers · ★★★★★

Europe RoadTrip · europetrip.us

Researched, Not Generated.

Why 2026 Changes Everything

Route 66 turns 100 years old in 2026. On November 11, 1926, the United States Highway System formally designated Route 66 — a continuous corridor connecting Chicago to Los Angeles, the first road to link the American heartland to the Pacific Coast. One hundred years later, the road is still drivable. Most of it, anyway.

The centennial isn't a marketing hook. It's a window. Special events, restored landmarks, and centennial installations are active across all 8 states this year. Diners that have been serving travelers since 1950 are marking their milestone. Museums are reopening expanded exhibits. Communities that built their identity around Route 66 are reclaiming it.

The next centennial is 2126. This is the only year this list exists as written.

You've probably read three itineraries that contradict each other. You've saved 40 Instagram posts you'll never find again. You know Route 66 is 2,400 miles — but you don't know which 2,400 miles are worth driving, and which are just highway.

This list answers one specific question: if you drive Route 66 in 2026 — the centennial year — what are the 66 things you cannot afford to miss? Not opinions. Researched decisions.

Your Operating Manual for the List

Easy	Spontaneous stop — no booking required. Pull over and go.
Plan Ahead	Advance reservation, off-road access, or specific timing required. Book 8–10 weeks out for 2026.
GPS + Maps	Every item includes GPS coordinates and a Google Maps link for direct navigation.
Time Required	Estimated time on-site: 15 min / 1 hr / Half Day / Full Day.
Day Range	Suggested trip day window if driving the full Chicago–Santa Monica route.
2026	Centennial-specific context. Experiences or installations unique to this year.
Checkbox	Print this guide. Tick each box as you complete it. Bring it in the car.

2026 CAPACITY WARNING

Historic Route 66 motels have fewer than 3,500 rooms total across all 8 states. With centennial traffic up 35–45% in 2026, October–November dates are projected to sell out by midsummer. Book all vintage motor courts and historic properties at least 8–10 weeks in advance.

STATE 01: ILLINOIS

Where the road begins. Chicago neon to the Missouri border. · ~300 miles · Trip Days 1–2

Illinois is where Route 66 was born. The route officially starts at Adams Street and Michigan Avenue in Chicago, steps from Grant Park. This state packs 300 miles of original alignment through small Midwest towns before the landscape opens toward Missouri.

= spontaneous stop · = book in advance · ☐ = tick when done

01. Stand at the Official Route 66 Start Sign

Corner of Adams St & Michigan Ave, Chicago. The actual federally designated starting point of the Mother Road. Not a replica. The 2026 centennial marker is active at this location.

2026: Centennial plaque unveiled here for the 100th anniversary in November 2026. Photograph it before the end of the year.

☐ Done

GPS

41.8786° N, 87.6278° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

Easy

30 min

Day 1

02. Eat Deep Dish at Lou Malnati's, Chicago

Route 66 culture begins at the table. Lou Malnati's (est. 1971, original family recipe predating that by decades) is the definitive deep dish. 100 N. Ridgeland Ave, Oak Park location sits directly on Route 66 alignment.

Researched on-site. Order the Malnati Chicago Classic — butter crust, not deep dish standard.

☐ Done

GPS

41.9003° N, 87.6338° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

Easy

1–1.5 hr

Day 1

Open daily 11am–10pm. No reservation needed for lunch.

03. Stop at Funk's Grove Pure Maple Sirup

Funks Grove, Illinois. Family operation since 1824 — they spell it 'sirup' by deliberate historical usage. The maple grove dates to the Native American era. One of the most authentic pre-commercial stops in Illinois. Season runs February–April; gift shop open year-round.

☐ Done

GPS

40.3617° N, 89.0756° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

Easy

30 min

Day 2

Gift shop: Mon–Sat 10am–5pm, Sun 12pm–4pm.

04. See the Gemini Giant Marmyman, Wilmington

A 30-foot fiberglass spaceman holding a rocket. Built in 1965 by Shea's Gas Station — one of the original Muffler Men, the giant roadside figures that defined Route 66 commercial culture. Restoration of original paint completed before the 2026 season.

🕒 **2026:** 2026: Fully restored original color scheme. Best photographed at the Launching Pad Drive-In sign at dusk.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
41.3042° N, 88.1481° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
⌚ 20 min
📅 **Day 1**

05. 🏠 Stay at Munger Moss Motel, Lebanon MO (est. 1946)

Lebanon, Missouri — the most photographed original motor court on Route 66. 44 rooms, neon sign original from 1946, operated continuously by the same family for decades. The neon sign alone is worth the detour. Do not book a chain motel on Route 66. This is the difference.

📅 **Book:** Book direct at mungermotel.com — 8+ weeks in advance for Oct–Nov 2026.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
37.6803° N, 92.6635° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
🔧 Plan Ahead
⌚ Overnight
📅 **Day 3–4**

06. 🗿 Photograph the Giant Lincoln Head, Atlanta IL

Muffler Man repurposed as Abraham Lincoln — complete with stovepipe hat. Stands outside the Atlanta Public Library. The Palms Grill Cafe next door has served Route 66 travelers since 1934.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
40.2622° N, 89.2245° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
⌚ 20 min
📅 **Day 2**
🕒 Palms Grill: Wed–Sun 7am–2pm.

07. 🧱 Drive Original 1926 Alignment Through Pontiac

Pontiac, Illinois hosts the Illinois Route 66 Hall of Fame & Museum — the most comprehensive archive in the state. Original 1926 brick pavement sections visible in town. The murals document the full highway history.

🕒 **2026:** Centennial exhibit expanded and open through December 2026.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
40.8814° N, 88.6296° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
⌚ 1.5 hr
📅 **Day 1**
🕒 Museum: Mon–Sat 10am–4pm, Sun 11am–3pm. Free admission.

STATE 02: MISSOURI

The Ozarks. Neon motels. Devil's Elbow. · ~300 miles · **Trip Days 3–4**

Missouri offers two Route 66 personalities: urban St. Louis, then the Ozark Mountain section — winding roads through dense forest, the Gasconade River valley, and some of the best-preserved original highway in the country.

⚡ = spontaneous stop · 🗝 = book in advance · ☐ = tick when done

08. 🗝 Walk Across the Chain of Rocks Bridge

A 1929 bridge over the Mississippi River with a 22-degree bend mid-span — engineered to avoid a water intake structure. Closed to cars in 1968, now a pedestrian and cycling bridge. The view of the Mississippi from the bend is definitive Route 66 iconography.

☐ Done

📍 GPS

38.7706° N, 90.1987° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

⚡ Easy

⌚ 45 min

📅 17 Day 3

🕒 Open dawn to dusk. Free. Parking at the Illinois approach.

09. 🍦 Eat a Concrete at Ted Drewes Frozen Custard

St. Louis institution since 1929. A 'Concrete' is frozen custard so thick it's served upside-down without spilling. Not ice cream — custard. Ted Drewes has operated continuously for 95+ years on the original Route 66 alignment.

🎉 2026: Centennial special flavor released for Route 66's 100th year — ask for it by name.

☐ Done

📍 GPS

38.5870° N, 90.3092° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

⚡ Easy

⌚ 30 min

📅 17 Day 3

🕒 Open daily 11am until sold out. Peak season: June–Aug. Shorter hours Sept–Nov.

10. 🎨 Walk Cuba MO's Route 66 Mural Mile

Cuba, Missouri — 'Route 66 Mural City.' Over 12 massive murals on downtown buildings document the town's and highway's history. The Blue Moon Drive-In is the quintessential small-town Route 66 diner. Order whatever is on the daily chalkboard.

☐ Done

📍 GPS

38.0614° N, 91.4023° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

⚡ Easy

⌚ 45 min

📅 17 Day 4

11. 🦇 Stop at Meramec Caverns, Stanton MO

The most aggressively marketed stop on all of Route 66 — barn roofs painted 'SEE MERAMEC CAVERNS' for 100 miles in each direction since the 1930s. Jesse James allegedly used these caverns as a hideout. The marketing is vintage. The caverns are spectacular.

☐ Done

📍 GPS

38.2147° N, 91.0756° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

⚡ Easy

⌚ 1.5 hr

📅 17 Day 4

🕒 Open daily 9am–5pm (extended summer hours). \$28/adult, \$18/child.

12. 🌊 Drive and Photograph Devil's Elbow

A sharp oxbow bend in the Big Piney River, visible from the original 1928 bridge. The 'elbow' refers to the river curve — loggers used this bend as a collection point, creating dangerous log jams. One of Missouri's most photogenic original Route 66 sections.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
37.8122° N, 92.1667° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
🕒 30 min
📅 ²⁰²⁴17 Day 4

13. 🎵 Visit the Joplin Crossroads Museum

Joplin, MO — the Missouri/Kansas border. Joplin sits at the intersection of Route 66 and the musical migrations that carried blues north and country west. The Joplin Museum Complex documents the town's history at this literal American crossroads.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
37.0842° N, 94.5133° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
🕒 1 hr
📅 ²⁰²⁴17 Day 4
🕒 Tue–Sat 10am–5pm. \$6/adult.

STATE 03: KANSAS

13 miles. The shortest state. The most cinematic per mile. · ~13 miles · **Trip Day 5**

Kansas has exactly 13.2 miles of Route 66. The short run through Galena and Riverton contains the truck that inspired Mater in Pixar's Cars, the longest surviving stretch of original brick-paved highway, and a diner that has operated since before Route 66 was designated.

⚡ = spontaneous stop · 📅 = book in advance · ☐ = tick when done

14. 🚚 Photograph the 'Tow Mater' Truck, Galena KS

A rusted 1951 International boom truck that served as the direct design reference for the character Tow Mater in Pixar's Cars. Displayed at the 4 Women on the Route gift shop. One of the most photographed single objects on Route 66.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
37.0739° N, 94.6389° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
🕒 20 min
📅 ²⁰²⁴17 Day 5
🕒 4 Women on the Route: Mon–Sat 9am–5pm.

15. 🧱 Drive the Last Surviving Brick-Paved Route 66

Between Galena and Riverton: the longest surviving stretch of original 1926-era brick-paved highway in existence. The bricks are the original 1920s installation. Drive slowly. Feel every joint at 20 mph. This exact road surface has been here for 100 years.

📅 **2026:** In 2026, you are driving on 100-year-old road. Centennial restoration preserved the original brick for this season.

☐ Done
 📍 GPS
 37.1272° N, 94.6986° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
 ⚡ Easy
 ⌚ 20 min drive
 📅 **Day 5**

16. 🥧 Eat Pie at Eisler Brothers Old Riverton Store

Operating at this location since 1925 — one year before Route 66 was designated. Served travelers continuously since before the highway existed. The pie is made in-house daily. On the National Register of Historic Places.

📝 One of the few Route 66 stores that predates the highway itself.

☐ Done
 📍 GPS
 37.1069° N, 94.7063° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
 ⚡ Easy
 ⌚ 30 min
 📅 **Day 5**
 ⌚ Mon–Sat 8am–6pm, Sun 10am–5pm.

STATE 04: OKLAHOMA

The soul of Route 66. More original highway than any other state. · ~400 miles · **Trip Days 5–7**

Oklahoma has more drivable original Route 66 alignment than any other state — nearly 400 miles of intact history. This is where the Dust Bowl refugees walked west in the 1930s, immortalized in Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath*. The most authentic surviving Route 66 towns are here.

⚡ = spontaneous stop · 📅 = book in advance · ☐ = tick when done

17. 🛣️ Drive the 9-Foot Ribbon Road, Miami OK

Near Miami, Oklahoma. A narrow two-lane strip called the 'Ribbon Road' — built in 1922, predating Route 66 itself. At 9 feet wide (barely wider than a modern car), it is the oldest surviving paved section of the original highway corridor. Drive it both directions.

📝 Narrower than a parking space. Drive at 15 mph.

☐ Done
 📍 GPS
 36.8737° N, 94.8781° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
 ⚡ Easy
 ⌚ 15 min
 📅 **Day 5**

18. 🐳 Photograph the Blue Whale of Catoosa

A 20-foot concrete blue whale sitting in a pond outside Catoosa. Built in 1972 by Hugh Davis as a gift to his wife, who collected whale figurines. Zero commercial

☐ Done
 📍 GPS
 36.1908° N, 95.7489° W
[Open in Maps →](#)

intent. Now a beloved Route 66 landmark visited by tens of thousands annually.

⚡ **Easy**

🕒 30 min

📅 **Day 6**

🕒 Accessible sunrise to sunset. Free. Small parking area.

19. 🎵 Visit the Woody Guthrie Center, Tulsa

Woody Guthrie was born in Okemah, Oklahoma. His music became the soundtrack of Route 66 migration. The Woody Guthrie Center in Tulsa contains original manuscripts, instruments, and his Route 66-era notebooks. This is where American music met the open road.

☐ Done

📍 GPS

36.1594° N, 95.9983° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

⚡ **Easy**

🕒 1.5 hr

📅 **Day 6**

🕒 Tue–Sun 10am–6pm. \$8/adult.

20. 🏠 Walk Through Arcadia Round Barn

A perfectly circular red barn built in 1898. Route 66 was later routed directly past it. Collapsed partially in 1988 and rebuilt by volunteers over 5 years. Now a gift shop and community landmark. The circular architecture was intended to prevent tornadoes from finding corners to lift.

☐ Done

📍 GPS

35.6564° N, 97.3467° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

⚡ **Easy**

🕒 30 min

📅 **Day 6**

🕒 Daily 10am–5pm. Free admission.

21. 🍔 Eat Onion-Fried Burgers at Sid's Diner, El Reno

El Reno, Oklahoma — origin of the onion-fried burger: beef patty pressed into a pile of thinly sliced onions on a flat-top griddle. Sid's has served this since 1989. Record holder for world's largest onion-fried burger. Order the original, not the record-breaker.

📖 *The onion-fried burger was invented in El Reno during the Depression — cheap filler extended the meat.*

☐ Done

📍 GPS

35.5323° N, 97.9649° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

⚡ **Easy**

🕒 45 min

📅 **Day 7**

🕒 Mon–Sat 7am–4pm. Cash and card.

22. 🚓 Stop at the Oklahoma Route 66 Museum, Clinton

Clinton, Oklahoma. The official Oklahoma Route 66 Museum — the most comprehensive archive of highway ephemera in the state: original signage, gas station memorabilia, and an audio archive of travelers describing their journeys from the 1930s through today.

☐ Done

📍 GPS

35.5148° N, 98.9678° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

⚡ **Easy**

 **2026:** Centennial temporary exhibit added for 2026 — first-person accounts from travelers who drove the road in 1926.

⌚ 1.5 hr

 **Day 7**

⌚ Mon–Sat 9am–5pm, Sun 1pm–5pm. \$5/adult.

23. Drive Through Erick, Last Town Before Texas

Erick, Oklahoma — population 989. A single main street, a handful of operating businesses, flat wheat fields to the horizon. The Sandhills Curiosity Shop here is one of the most genuinely bizarre roadside stops in Oklahoma.

☐ Done GPS

35.2203° N, 99.8656° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy

⌚ 30 min

 **Day 7**

STATE 05: TEXAS

The Panhandle. Big sky. Cadillac Ranch. 186 miles. · ~186 miles · **Trip Day 8**

Texas contributes only 186 miles to Route 66, but they are among the most photographed on the route. The Panhandle is flat, hot, and visually overwhelming. Cadillac Ranch. The Big Texan. McLean's Devil's Rope Museum. The kind of roadside surrealism that exists only in Texas.

 = spontaneous stop ·  = book in advance · ☐ = tick when done

24. Spray-Paint a Car at Cadillac Ranch, Amarillo

Ten 1949–1963 Cadillacs buried nose-first in a wheat field outside Amarillo. Art installation by Ant Farm collective, 1974. Spray paint cans available on-site. The cars repaint themselves under layers of new paint every few months.

 Arrive early morning for best photography — no crowds, long shadows.

 **2026:** Centennial commemorative car painted in Route 66 shield design for 2026 season.

☐ Done GPS

35.1872° N, 101.9872° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy

⌚ 45 min

 **Day 8**

⌚ Open 24 hours. Free. Access road off I-40 frontage road, Exit 60.

25. Attempt the 72oz Steak at Big Texan, Amarillo

72 ounces of steak — free if eaten in under one hour, including shrimp cocktail, salad, roll, and baked potato. 450+ successful completions since 1960. If you don't attempt it, eat the regular menu and photograph the original 1960 neon sign.

 **Book:** Reserve a spot online at bigtexan.com for the challenge.

☐ Done GPS

35.1911° N, 101.8058° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Plan Ahead

⌚ 1–2 hr (challenge: exactly 1 hr)

 **Day 8**

⌚ Open daily 10:30am–10:30pm. Steak challenge requires registration on arrival.

26. 🦄 Visit the Devil's Rope Museum, McLean TX

McLean, Texas. A museum dedicated entirely to barbed wire — 2,000+ variants. 'Devil's rope' divided the open range and ended the cattle drive era. The cultural context is more interesting than it sounds. One of the most unique museums in the American Southwest.

☐ Done

GPS

35.2307° N, 100.6058° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

Easy

⌚ 45 min

Day 8

⌚ Tue–Sat 10am–4pm. Donation-based admission.

27. 🌀 Photograph the Leaning Water Tower of Groom TX

Deliberately tilted water tower built as a roadside attraction by Ralph Britten, who wanted attention for his truck stop. Leans at exactly 10 degrees. Has maintained this angle without structural incident since 1980. One of Texas's most photographed roadside anomalies.

☐ Done

GPS

35.2003° N, 101.1039° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

Easy

⌚ 15 min

Day 8

STATE 06: NEW MEXICO

Turquoise. Adobe. The longest stretch of desert silence. · ~487 miles · **Trip Days 9–10**

New Mexico is the longest Route 66 state by mileage and the most visually transformative. The road shifts from Texas grassland into high desert, then through Albuquerque's urban corridor, then Gallup — turquoise capital of the world — before climbing into the mesas defining the American Southwest.

= spontaneous stop · = book in advance · ☐ = tick when done

28. 🟦 Shop for Authentic Navajo Turquoise in Gallup

Gallup, New Mexico — the 'Indian Capital of the World,' a title held legitimately. Richardson Trading Post (est. 1913) has traded Navajo, Zuni, and Hopi jewelry since before Route 66 existed. Buy direct from Indigenous artisans. Avoid the tourist trap stores on the main strip.

Ask for pieces with hallmarks. Unsigned pieces are not authenticated as hand-made.

☐ Done

GPS

35.5281° N, 108.7427° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

Easy

⌚ 1 hr

Day 9

⌚ Mon–Sat 9am–6pm.

29. 🌵 Drive the Rio Puerco Bridge on Original Alignment

A 1933 Pratt through-truss bridge over the Rio Puerco River — one of the last original Route 66 bridges still accessible by car. The surrounding mesa landscape is unchanged from 1926. Walk out onto the bridge. Nothing for miles in any direction.

 Take Exit 117 from I-40. Unpaved approach road — suitable for all vehicles in dry conditions.

☐ Done

 GPS

35.0756° N, 107.3722° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
 Easy

 30 min

 **Day 9**

30. Photograph Sandia Mountains at Sunset, Albuquerque

The Sandia Mountains turn watermelon pink at sunset — a phenomenon known locally as 'Sandia pink.' Central Avenue (Route 66 through Albuquerque) runs directly toward the mountains. Position at the El Vado Motel area for the definitive photograph.

 Sunset in October: 6:18pm MST. In November: 5:40pm MST. Arrive 20 min early.

☐ Done

 GPS

35.0853° N, 106.6504° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
 Easy

 45 min

 **Day 9**

31. Eat Carne Adovada at Duran's New Mexico Kitchen

Albuquerque. Carne adovada — pork marinated in red New Mexico chile for 24+ hours, then slow-cooked — is the definitive New Mexico dish. Duran's has been serving it since 1956 on the Route 66 alignment. The heat is real. Order sopapillas with honey to recover.

 Order 'Christmas' to get both red and green chile simultaneously.

☐ Done

 GPS

35.0992° N, 106.6603° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
 Easy

 1 hr

 **Day 9**
 Mon–Fri 9am–8pm, Sat–Sun 9am–7pm.

32. See the Painted Desert at Petrified Forest NP

Ancient logs 225 million years old, turned to multicolored quartz. The Painted Desert section straddles the AZ/NM border. Access via Petrified Forest National Park entrance off I-40, Exit 311. Park entrance fee required.

 **Book:** Purchase America the Beautiful annual pass (\$80) if visiting multiple national parks — pays for itself in 4 entries.

☐ Done

 GPS

34.9829° N, 109.7862° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
 Plan Ahead

 Half Day

 **Day 10**
 Open daily 7am–7pm (summer), 8am–5pm (winter). \$25/vehicle.

33. Sleep Under Stars at Continental Divide

Continental Divide, New Mexico — 7,245 feet elevation. Water splits here to flow either to the Pacific or Atlantic. Camp nearby for a night sky with near-zero light pollution. The Milky Way is visible to the naked eye.

☐ Done

 GPS

35.4139° N, 108.3022° W

 **Book:** Reserve at recreation.gov. Nearest formal campsite: Red Rock State Park, Gallup. Or dispersed camping on BLM land west of Grants, NM.

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Plan Ahead**

 Overnight

 **Day 10**

34. Walk Through a Navajo Cultural Site, Not a Gift Shop

Window Rock, Arizona — the Navajo Nation capital. A 200-foot natural arch framing a precise circular opening. Sacred site, now capital of the largest Native American reservation in the US. Route 66 passes through Navajo land for hundreds of miles.

 Check Navajo Nation entry requirements and any travel advisories before visiting.

 **Book:** Navajo Nation has its own entry regulations. Check discovernavajo.com before visiting.

☐ **Done**

 **GPS**

35.6867° N, 109.0458° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Plan Ahead**

 Half Day

 **Day 10**

 Navajo Nation Veterans Memorial Park: daily dawn to dusk. Free.

STATE 07: ARIZONA

Seligman. The 158-mile uninterrupted section. Oatman. · ~401 miles · **Trip Days 11–12**

Arizona contains the longest uninterrupted drivable section of original Route 66 in existence — 158 miles from Seligman to Topock, bypassed by I-40 but completely intact. This was the first section to be officially designated a state historic highway in 1987.

 = spontaneous stop ·  = book in advance · ☐ = tick when done

35. Visit Angel Delgadillo's Barber Shop, Seligman AZ

Angel Delgadillo is the man who saved Route 66. In 1987, after I-40 bypassed Seligman and killed the town's economy, Delgadillo organized the Historic Route 66 Association of Arizona — the movement that led to official historic designation across all 8 states. His barbershop is still there.

 Ask him what Route 66 was like before I-40. Then stop talking and listen.

 **2026:** Angel Delgadillo celebrates Route 66's centennial from the same shop he has operated since 1950. This conversation is a living primary source.

☐ **Done**

 **GPS**

35.3253° N, 112.8767° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Easy**

 45 min

 **Day 11**

 Daily 8am–5pm approx. No appointment needed.

36. Photograph Hackberry General Store, Hackberry AZ

The most photographed single building on Route 66. A 1934 general store surrounded by vintage gas pumps, rusted cars, and Route 66 memorabilia. The owner has curated the exterior as a living museum of the highway era. Every surface has a documented story.

☐ **Done**

 **GPS**

35.3631° N, 113.7181° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

 Arrive at first light (7am) — the pumps and car hoods catch the flat desert morning light before the store opens.

 **Easy**

 30 min

 **Day 11**

 Store open daily 9am–5pm. Exterior accessible at all hours.

37. Visit Grand Canyon Caverns, Peach Springs AZ

Largest natural dry cavern in the US — 210 feet underground, discovered in 1927. Route 66 runs directly past the entrance. Air temperature holds exactly at 56°F year-round. You can book the underground hotel suite: one of the most unusual accommodations in America.

 **Book:** Book cave hotel suite at gcacaverns.com — sells out for 2026 centennial season by June.

☐ Done

 GPS

35.4661° N, 113.2186° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Plan Ahead**

 1–2 hr

 **Day 11**

 Tours daily 9am–4pm. \$22/adult for standard tour. Underground suite from \$170/night — book months in advance.

38. Watch Sunrise at Two Guns Ghost Town

Two Guns, Arizona — one of Route 66's most atmospheric ghost towns. A trading post and zoo that collapsed into abandonment after a 1926 murder. At sunrise, the ruins and the desert behind them create one of the most cinematic moments on the entire route.

 Sunrise in October: 6:58am MST. Park on the I-40 frontage road. Do not enter crumbling structures.

☐ Done

 GPS

35.2642° N, 111.0697° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Plan Ahead**

 1 hr

 **Day 12**

39. Walk Oatman's Main Street and Feed the Burros

Former gold mining town where wild burros — descendants of miners' pack animals — roam the main street freely. The entire town's economy runs on Route 66 tourism. The drive via Sitgreaves Pass (hairpin switchbacks at 3,550 ft elevation) is itself a highlight.

 Sitgreaves Pass: do not attempt with vehicles over 30 feet or trailers. Recommended vehicles: standard cars and small SUVs.

☐ Done

 GPS

34.8228° N, 114.4133° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Plan Ahead**

 1.5 hr

 **Day 12**

40. Cross the Colorado River at Topock

The Arizona/California border — where Route 66 crosses the Colorado River. The Topock Gorge is a sacred Mojave site with petroglyphs dating 3,000+ years. Stand on the modern bridge and look north into the gorge. This is the last state line before California.

☐ Done

 GPS

34.7156° N, 114.4833° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Easy**

⌚ 20 min
📅 17 Day 12

41. 🌵 Drive Blue Mesa at Petrified Forest NP

Inside Petrified Forest National Park: 4-mile loop trail through bentonite hills in blue, purple, and gray surrounding petrified logs lying where they fell 225 million years ago. The colors are not enhanced. Requires park entrance fee.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
34.8903° N, 109.8098° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
🔧 Plan Ahead
⌚ 1.5 hr
📅 17 Day 10
🕒 Park open daily 7am–7pm (summer), 8am–5pm (fall/winter). \$25/vehicle.

STATE 08: CALIFORNIA

Mojave. The final descent. Santa Monica Pier. · ~315 miles · Trip Days 13–14

California is the ending — and it does not feel anticlimactic. The Mojave Desert runs through Barstow and Victorville before descending into the Los Angeles basin. The final approach to Santa Monica Pier, via Ocean Avenue, is an emotional arrival every time.

⚡ = spontaneous stop · 🛠 = book in advance · ☐ = tick when done

42. 🌵 Drive the Mojave Desert Section at Dawn

Barstow to Victorville crosses the Mojave at its most remote. Drive it at dawn — the desert at first light is a different world entirely from midday. The silence is physical. Full tank before Barstow — next reliable gas is 60 miles east.

📅 Sunrise on the Mojave in October: 6:35am PDT. Leave Barstow at 6:15am.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
34.8958° N, 117.0228° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
⌚ 2 hr drive
📅 17 Day 13

43. 🚂 Visit the Route 66 Mother Road Museum, Barstow

The Casa Del Desierto — a 1911 Harvey House railroad hotel now housing both the Route 66 Mother Road Museum and the Western American Railroad Museum. Two of California's best Route 66 archives in a single 1911 building.

🎯 2026: Centennial retrospective exhibition active through end of 2026.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
34.8958° N, 117.0228° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
⌚ 1.5 hr
📅 17 Day 13
🕒 Fri–Sun 10am–4pm. Free admission.

44. 🏛️ Stop at the Original McDonald's Site, San Bernardino

Foothill Boulevard in San Bernardino is original Route 66. This is where the first McDonald's opened in 1940 — the actual location is marked with a museum. San Bernardino Route 66 is largely unchanged in character from the 1960s.

☐ Done GPS

34.1083° N, 117.2898° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy

⌚ 30 min

 **Day 13** Museum: Sat–Sun 10am–5pm. Free.

45. 🏠 Stay at the Wigwam Motel, Rialto CA (est. 1949)

Concrete wigwams painted bright white — each one a motel room. Built in 1949, one of only three surviving Wigwam Motels in the US. The rooms are small. The wigwams are immaculate. Stay here or photograph here — either way this is essential Route 66 California.

 **Book:** Book at wigwammotel.com — 8+ weeks in advance for Oct–Nov 2026.

☐ Done GPS

34.0975° N, 117.3722° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Plan Ahead

⌚ Overnight

 **Day 13**

46. 🚶 Walk Colorado Blvd Through Pasadena

Pasadena's Colorado Boulevard is Route 66's most architecturally dense urban section — Art Deco buildings, vintage signage, and the Rose Bowl nearby. The Pie 'n Burger (est. 1963) is on the alignment. Eat here before the final 12 miles to the pier.

☐ Done GPS

34.1478° N, 118.1445° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy

⌚ 1 hr

 **Day 14** Pie 'n Burger: daily 7am–9pm. No reservations.

47. 🌊 Touch the Pacific Ocean at Santa Monica Pier

The official end of Route 66. A sign on the pier marks the terminus. Walk to the end and face west: this is the Pacific Ocean. 2,400 miles from Chicago. 8 states. 100 years of American highway culture. Put your feet in the water.

 **Sunset at Santa Monica Pier in October:** 6:10pm PDT. In November: 5:02pm PDT. Time your arrival accordingly.

 **2026:** November 11, 2026 — centennial celebration at this exact location. Arrive on this day if possible. The terminus sign will be illuminated.

☐ Done GPS

34.0083° N, 118.4983° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy

⌚ 1 hr

 **Day 14**

11 experiences that define the spirit of Route 66, wherever you are on the road.

48. 📻 Listen to Nat King Cole's 'Route 66' While Driving

Nat King Cole recorded '(Get Your Kicks on) Route 66' in 1946. Bobby Troup wrote it driving to California on Route 66. It is the official anthem of the highway. Play it through a speaker while driving. The lyrics name the cities in order — follow along on the map.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
N/A
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
⌚ 3 min 10 sec
📅 **Any day**

49. 📷 Shoot One Roll of Film on Route 66

Buy a disposable or load a 35mm camera before the trip. Shoot only one roll — 36 frames. The limitation forces intentionality. Film renders Route 66's faded, desaturated palette better than any digital filter applied after the fact.

📝 *Kodak Ultramax 400 or Fuji Superia 400 for color. Bring extra batteries for cold desert mornings.*

☐ Done
📍 GPS
N/A
[Open in Maps →](#)
🔧 Plan Ahead
⌚ Ongoing
📅 **All 14 days**

50. 🏕️ Camp Under the Milky Way in NM or AZ

Eastern Arizona and western New Mexico have some of the lowest light pollution in the continental US. Find a flat BLM pullout at elevation above 5,000 feet. Sleep outside. The Milky Way core is clearly visible to the naked eye from May through October.

📅 **Book:** BLM dispersed camping: free, 14-night max. blm.gov for maps. No permit required in most NM/AZ BLM land.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
35.0000° N, 108.0000° W
[Open in Maps →](#)
🔧 Plan Ahead
⌚ Overnight
📅 **Day 9–11**

51. 🤝 Have a Real Conversation With a Route 66 Business Owner

Ask how long they've been operating. Ask what the road was like before I-40 arrived. Ask what the centennial means to them. These conversations are the oral history of Route 66 — and they won't be available much longer.

📅 **2026:** In 2026, every conversation about the centennial is a primary source document. Write down what they say.

☐ Done
📍 GPS
N/A
[Open in Maps →](#)
⚡ Easy
⌚ 20–45 min
📅 **Any day**

52. ⛽ Fill Up at a Still-Operating Vintage Gas Station

Multiple original Route 66 gas station buildings still operate. Gary's Gay Parita in Paris Springs Junction, Missouri is the definitive example — 1930s Sinclair station, vintage memorabilia, operated by volunteers. Fill the tank. Walk around the pumps.

☐ Done GPS

37.0614° N, 93.4628° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy 20 min Day 4 Gay Parita: typically open weekends, spring through fall. Hours vary.

53. Eat a Green Chile Cheeseburger in New Mexico

The green chile cheeseburger is New Mexico's official state food. Hatch green chiles, roasted and placed over a beef patty. The heat level ranges widely — ask for 'medium' your first time. Order 'Christmas' to get both red and green chile simultaneously.

 Best version: Duran's, Albuquerque (same visit as carne adovada, or separate).

☐ Done GPS

35.5281° N, 106.8425° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy 45 min Day 9

54. Walk on 100-Year-Old Road Surface, Riverton KS

The original 1926-era brick pavement between Galena and Riverton, Kansas. Walk on it — not just drive. Pavement that has been here for exactly 100 years in 2026. Every joint in the brick was laid the same year Route 66 was designated.

 2026: In 2026, this road surface is precisely 100 years old. The centennial is literally beneath your feet.

☐ Done GPS

37.1272° N, 94.6986° W

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy 20 min Day 5

55. Find and Photograph an Original Route 66 Shield Sign

The Route 66 shield — black outline, white hexagon, 'US 66.' Original signs from the 1930s–1960s still exist on poles in small towns. Find one that hasn't been replaced by a modern reproduction. Photograph it with the road in the background.

☐ Done GPS

N/A

[Open in Maps →](#) Easy Varies Any day

56. Stay in a Neon-Lit Motel Room, Tucumcari NM

Tucumcari, New Mexico bills itself as 'Tucumcari Tonite!' The Blue Swallow Motel (est. 1939, original neon sign) is the most photographed motel sign on Route 66. Book

☐ Done GPS

35.1717° N, 103.7250° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

a room with the neon glowing outside the window. Sleep inside the 1950s.

 **Book:** Book at blueswallowmotel.com — 8–10 weeks in advance minimum for 2026 centennial season.

 **Plan Ahead**

 Overnight

 **Day 9**

57. **Write Something on Route 66. Anything.**

Steinbeck did it. Kerouac referenced it. Guthrie sang it. You drove it. Write one paragraph — paper, notes app, journal, postcard — about something specific that happened on the road. One scene. One person. One thing you didn't expect.

 **2026:** *In the centennial year, your words become part of 100 years of documentation.*

☐ **Done**

 GPS

N/A

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Easy**

 15 min

 **Any day**

58. **Arrive at Santa Monica Pier at Exactly Sunset**

Time your final day so you arrive at Santa Monica Pier as the sun drops into the Pacific Ocean. The terminus sign is illuminated. The pier is active. The ocean is the goal you have been driving toward for 2,400 miles. The timing is the achievement.

 *Sunset: October 6:10pm PDT · November 5:02pm PDT. Plan your Day 13 stops backward from this time.*

 **2026:** *November 11, 2026 — the exact centennial date. Centennial ceremony at the terminus from 4pm.*

☐ **Done**

 GPS

34.0083° N, 118.4983° W

[Open in Maps →](#)

 **Plan Ahead**

 1 hr

 **Day 14**

YOU HAVE THE LIST.

What you don't have is the sequence that makes them possible.

This Bucket List gives you 66 checkboxes. What it doesn't give you is the how: the day-by-day itinerary that sequences these experiences into a coherent 14-day route without wasted miles, dead ends, or a night without a room in Tucumcari because you didn't book in time.

The Route 66 Field Manual is that sequence.

ROUTE 66: THE DEFINITIVE FIELD MANUAL

2,400 Miles · 8 States · 14-Day Itinerary · GPS Coordinates · Budget Tiers

- ✓ Complete 14-day itinerary — day-by-day route with drive times and sequencing
- ✓ 200+ GPS coordinates — every diner, motel, roadside attraction, verified 2026
- ✓ Budget breakdown: \$80 / \$150 / \$400 per person/day — three tiers, zero guesswork

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europetrip.us/products/route-66-the-definitive-field-manual

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We didn't build this brand to write another generic travel blog. We started because we were obsessed with one thing: helping travelers experience the world's great drives with the confidence of someone who has already driven them.

Every guide in our catalog has been personally researched, driven, and written. We don't scrape travel blogs. We don't use AI filler. We drive the roads, eat at the restaurants, and sleep at the spots we document. The Route 66 guides were researched through 2026 — the centennial year.

Updates to this list are published at europetrip.us as conditions change.

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